



BOTTLED RELIEF

A MAN tries to cool off with a chilled bottle of mineral water in Delhi in the middle of a hotter than usual and earlier than expected summer. According to the Meteorological Department, maximum temperatures have shown a rise across India.

BADAL (SECOND FROM RIGHT) WITH THE KABBADI TEAM



IF TELEVISION SETS ARE POLITICAL SOPS IN SOME PARTS OF THE COUNTRY, THE PUNJAB CHIEF MINISTER BET ON SPORTS AND EVEN A FEW TRACTORS.

PUNJAB | Hold Your Breath

Just like distributing rice and tv sets are the usual political sops in some parts of India, in Punjab it seems to be sports. Ignoring constant criticism from the Opposition for "wasting" precious time and resources, Punjab's Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal went all the way to focus attention on the neglected rural sport of kabaddi. A 10-day World Cub Kabaddi tournament organised in the state was a resounding success in the countryside. The winning Indian team couldn't have been happier: not only did they pocket the Rs 1-crore prize money but its players have also been promised respectable government jobs. Some players even won tractors as prizes. All this while, Badal claimed that the tournament had better TRP ratings than even the IPL. Now the enthusiastic Badal Junior's next aim is to take another popular Punjab sport to greater heights. Coming up: an eight-nation hockey tournament. **by Arvind Chhabra**